

1985

DEADLY STRIKE



The third worst mid-air disaster saw Air-India's Boeing 747 *Kanishka*, flying from Toronto to Bombay, plunging into a watery grave with 329 passengers on board. As evidence piled up, it became clear that a terrorist's bomb had made the flight disappear from the radar screens. Part of a larger plan, another bomb went off in Tokyo's Narita airport killing two people. With it the fight for Khalistan, finally, reached foreign shores. The long drawn-out investigation led to the arrests of Khalistani militants Ripudaman Singh Malik and Ajaib Singh Bagri. To this day, revelations pour out. The latest: A former Vancouver policeman has testified that Sikh militants had warned Indians not to fly Air-India weeks before the blast.

LIBERAL SWEEP

On August 20, Sant Harchand Singh Longowal, who signed the Punjab Accord with Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi on July 24, with a promise of peace and free elections, was assassinated by Sikh extremists. His death created a sympathy wave for the



Akali Dal, and S.S. Barnala (left) rode to power for the first time in the September Assembly elections.

FIRST CUT

The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) was

established on December 8, with India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Nepal, Maldives and Bhutan as members.